

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Project Management English

Vocabulary & phrasebook

Keep precise meanings and useful expressions close. Retrieve the words, then use them in a complete message.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Find the right language. Speak, write, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For project managers, program managers, PMO staff, scrum masters, delivery leads, operations managers, and cross-functional coordinators.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Make vocabulary usable

Knowing a definition is a start. To use a term well, explain it in plain English, connect it to a case, and choose a natural sentence around it.

- Read five terms, cover their definitions, and recall the meanings.
- Sort a pair you might confuse and explain the difference.
- Use one term in a sentence about a fictional case.
- Ask a partner to explain the sentence without repeating the specialist word.
- Return to the same terms on another day and test recall again.

Abbreviations need context

Expand an abbreviation on first use when the listener needs it. Some abbreviations have different meanings across professions: API can refer to an application programming interface or an active pharmaceutical ingredient. The course context determines the meaning.

Definitions have limits

These are concise language-learning explanations, not complete legal, clinical, or technical specifications. Use the applicable authoritative definition for regulated or operational decisions.

Field vocabulary A-Z

acceptance criteria

Specific conditions a deliverable must meet to be accepted.

action item

A specific task agreed during a discussion, usually assigned to a person.

assumption

Something treated as true for planning or reasoning, though it may need verification.

baseline

A defined starting value or agreed reference used to measure change.

buffer

Extra time, stock, or capacity reserved to absorb variation or delay.

change request

A proposal to alter an agreed product, scope, schedule, or process.

charter

A document establishing a project's purpose, objectives, scope, and authority.

critical path

Sequence of dependent work that determines the shortest feasible timeline.

decision ask

A clear statement of the decision requested from an audience.

decision rights

The allocation of authority to recommend, approve, or make particular decisions.

deliverable

A specified item of work to be provided to a customer or project recipient.

dependency

Work, approval, input, vendor, system, or decision that another activity relies on.

escalation

Raising an issue to a higher authority or different function because risk, urgency, or decision rights require it.

exclusion

Something outside an agreed scope or expressly not covered by a policy or agreement.

governance

Decision structure defining roles, rights, approvals, controls, and accountability.

impact analysis

An examination of the effects a proposed change may have.

issue log

A record of current problems, their impacts, owners, and resolution status.

lesson learned

A specific insight from experience that can guide future practice.

milestone

A significant planned point or achievement used to track progress.

mitigation

Action taken to reduce likelihood, impact, or exposure of a risk.

owner

Named person or role accountable for a decision, action, deliverable, or risk.

postmortem

Structured review after an incident or project to identify causes, impacts, lessons, and actions.

RACI

A responsibility framework identifying who is responsible, accountable, consulted, and informed.

RAG status

Red, amber, or green status assigned using stated reporting criteria.

risk register

A record of identified risks, their assessments, owners, and planned responses.

root cause

Underlying reason a problem occurred, not merely the visible symptom.

scope

Defined boundary of work, responsibility, deliverables, assumptions, and exclusions.

scope creep

Expansion of work beyond the agreed scope without corresponding agreement on its effects.

SLA

Service-level agreement defining expected service performance or response commitments.

status report

A summary of progress, open issues, and relevant next decisions at a stated time.

steering committee

A group that oversees an initiative and resolves major direction or governance questions.

trend

A direction or pattern observed across multiple points in time.

Expressions for this course

Complete the frames with the facts of your case. A frame helps organize meaning; it should not replace an actual explanation.

Ask a precise question

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Give a useful status update

We have completed ...; ... remains open.

As of ..., the status is

The next update will cover

Lead with the current state, then the important change or open item. Use completed-action language only for completed work. Add a next update point when it is known; do not invent a date to make the message sound complete.

Match certainty to evidence

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Help a group reach a clear next step

Let's hear ... before we decide.

The point we still need to resolve is

Who will make this decision, and what do they need?

Summarize the issue neutrally, invite missing perspectives, and distinguish discussion from decision. State who can decide and record any unresolved question. Do not assume silence means agreement.

Offer a workable tradeoff

We can ..., provided that

Would you prefer ... or ...?

I can take that proposal for review; I cannot yet confirm

Acknowledge the goal and explain the available choices. Connect an offer to its actual conditions. A useful response makes room for discussion without promising approval or resources you do not control.

Ask for an actionable next step

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Give feedback people can use

In [specific situation], I noticed

The effect was What was happening from your perspective?

Could we agree to ... and review it ...?

Use a specific example instead of a personality label. Explain its effect, invite the person's perspective, and agree on a practical improvement. Focus on communication that can be changed, not accent or national identity.

Model responses in context

Read the situation first. Cover the model, say your own response, and compare the two for meaning and tone.

01 | Project Charter and Scope Definition

A sponsor requests a dashboard but the brief does not define users, decisions, or excluded features.

Who will use the dashboard, and what decision should it support? Let's agree on those needs and the exclusions before we estimate the work or call the scope complete.

Try it again: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

02 | Schedule, Critical Path, and Dependencies

A testing task is three days late and blocks the release rehearsal. Other work is on schedule.

Testing is three days late and is blocking the release rehearsal. Other tasks remain on schedule. I'll show the dependency and the proposed recovery options in the schedule update.

Try it again: The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

03 | Risk Register and Issue Escalation

A risk register still lists a supplier delay as a possibility, although the supplier has confirmed it will miss the delivery date.

The delay is now a confirmed issue, not only a future risk. I'll update its status and ask the responsible owner to document the impact and next action.

Try it again: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

04 | Stakeholder Alignment and Governance

A project meeting ends with several recommendations but no indication of who approves the change.

We have a recommendation, but approval is still outstanding. Who has authority to approve this change, and what information do they need? I'll record the decision route in the meeting notes.

Try it again: A participant interrupts or the meeting is running out of time. Protect a turn to speak and close with an accurate decision record.

05 | Change Requests and Scope Creep

A sponsor asks for a new report two weeks before launch. The team can add it only by moving another feature or extending the schedule.

We can assess the new report as a scope change. To include it, we would need to move another feature or extend the schedule. Which tradeoff should we develop for review?

Try it again: The preferred option is unavailable. Offer an alternative and clearly state any approval still needed.

06 | Status Reporting and Executive Updates

A project is labeled green despite an unresolved dependency that threatens its planned date. The reporting criteria require material threats to be visible.

The current label does not show the unresolved dependency. I'll report the delivery threat, its impact, and the decision needed so the status reflects the agreed criteria.

Try it again: The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

07 | Vendor and Cross-Functional Delivery

A vendor says a deliverable is complete, but the team cannot find evidence for two acceptance criteria.

Could you provide the evidence for these two criteria or identify any outstanding work?
We need to review the deliverable against the agreed criteria before confirming acceptance.

Try it again: The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

08 | Post-Implementation Review

A project review repeatedly says "communication was poor." The team has no concrete improvement action.

Which message or handoff caused difficulty, and what happened as a result? Let's turn that example into a specific change, assign an owner, and decide how we will check whether it helped.

Try it again: The recipient disagrees with your interpretation. Return to the observed example, listen, and revise an unsupported assumption.

Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.